

RRB NTPC & SSC Tier-1 / Tier-2

Combined Master Question Bank

Subject: General Awareness (Ancient History & Himalayan Drainage System)

Pattern Benchmark: TCS / NRA Advanced Framework

SECTION A: ANCIENT INDIAN HISTORY (15 MCQ Master Bank)

Part 1: Advanced Conceptual Questions (SSC CGL 2025 Prelims Pattern)

Question 1: In the district administration (Vishaya) of the Gupta Empire, which of the following terms was explicitly used to designate the "Chief Artisan" who served on the advisory council alongside the Vishayapati?

- (A) Sarthavaha
- (B) Prathama-Kulika
- (C) Nagarasreshti
- (D) Pustapala

Correct Answer: (B) Prathama-Kulika

Explanation: The local district administration in the Gupta period featured a representative council assisting the district head. Prathama-Kulika was the chief artisan, Nagarasreshti was the chief merchant/banker of the city, Sarthavaha represented the mobile caravan traders, and Pustapala was the land record-keeper.

Verified Source: Gupta Administrative Inscriptions (Damodarpur Copper Plates)

Question 2: During the reign of the Pallavas of Kanchi, what specific institutional term was applied to the elite, higher educational assemblies or colleges predominantly attached to temples for Vedic learning?

- (A) Ghatikas
- (B) Agraharas
- (C) Erivirappattanas
- (D) Salais

Correct Answer: (A) Ghatikas

Explanation: The Pallavas patronised traditional learning institutions. The Ghatikas were prominent institutional centres or colleges of higher learning active in Kanchi. Agraharas were tax-free land grants made to Brahmins, while Erivirappattanas were fortified commercial towns managed by merchant guilds.

Verified Source: Pallava Epigraphical Records (Kasakudi Plates)

Question 3: In the administrative system of the Gupta Empire, which of the following officials was explicitly responsible for maintaining and managing public land records and registration logs at the district (Vishaya) level?

- (A) Mahattara
- (B) Saulkika
- (C) Pustapala
- (D) Audrangika

Correct Answer: (C) Pustapala

Explanation: Under Gupta provincial administration, the district head (Vishayapati) relied heavily on a structured bureaucracy. The Pustapala served as the official record-keeper or registrar who maintained the documentation of land holdings, valuations, and transfers.

Verified Source: Gupta Administrative Inscriptions (SSC CGL 2025 Prelims)

Question 4: The Sohgaura Copper Plate inscription, widely recognized by historians as the earliest known epigraphic record detailing state-sponsored famine relief measures and the construction of public granaries, belongs to the reign of which ancient Indian dynasty?

- (A) Mauryan Dynasty
- (B) Nanda Dynasty
- (C) Shunga Dynasty
- (D) Haryanka Dynasty

Correct Answer: (A) Mauryan Dynasty

Explanation: The Sohgaura Copper Plate Inscription (discovered in Gorakhpur, Uttar Pradesh) is written in the Prakrit language using the Brahmi script. It dates back to the Mauryan period, likely during the reign of Chandragupta Maurya. The inscription specifically outlines state orders for distributing food reserves from imperial storehouses during public distress (famine), providing rare archaeological evidence of the welfare state model described in Kautilya's Arthashastra.

Verified Source: Mauryan Epigraphical Records (SSC CGL 2025 Prelims)

Question 5: Match the following core schools of Ancient Indian Philosophy (Shad-Darshana) with their legendary founding sages:

1. Nyaya — i. Sage Kapila
2. Samkhya — ii. Sage Kanada
3. Vaisheshika — iii. Sage Gautama
4. Yoga — iv. Sage Patanjali

(A) 1-i, 2-iii, 3-ii, 4-iv

(B) 1-iii, 2-i, 3-ii, 4-iv

(C) 1-iii, 2-ii, 3-i, 4-iv

(D) 1-ii, 2-i, 3-iii, 4-iv

Correct Answer: (B) 1-iii, 2-i, 3-ii, 4-iv

Explanation: The Shad-Darshanas (Six Schools of Indian Philosophy) have seen a major analytical resurgence in recent official question structures. The remaining two schools are Mimamsa (founded by Sage Jaimini) and Vedanta/Uttara Mimamsa (founded by Sage Badarayana).

Verified Source: Ancient Philosophical Textual Standard

Part 2: High-Frequency Previous Year Questions (PYQs)

Question 6: The national motto of India, 'Satyameva Jayate' (Truth Alone Triumphs), is inscribed below the State Emblem of India. From which ancient scripture is this motto taken?

- (A) Katha Upanishad
- (B) Mundaka Upanishad
- (C) Chandogya Upanishad
- (D) Prashna Upanishad

Correct Answer: (B) Mundaka Upanishad

Explanation: 'Satyameva Jayate' is a mantra from the Mundaka Upanishad, which is associated with the Atharvaveda.

Exam Repetitions: RRB NTPC (2016, 2020, 2021), RRB Group D (2018, 2022), SSC CGL/CHSL (2017, 2019, 2020, 2022)

Question 7: Which site of the Indus Valley Civilization is famous for containing an artificial brick dockyard for maritime trade?

- (A) Kalibangan
- (B) Mohenjo-Daro
- (C) Lothal
- (D) Dholavira

Correct Answer: (C) Lothal

Explanation: Lothal, located in Gujarat along the Bhogava River (a tributary of the Sabarmati), served as a major port city of the Harappan civilization, connecting trade routes with Mesopotamia.

Exam Repetitions: RRB NTPC CBT-1 (2016, 2021, 2022), RRB ALP/JE (2018, 2019), SSC CGL/CPO (2018, 2020, 2022, 2023)

Question 8: Where was the Fourth Buddhist Council held, and who was the patron king under whose reign it was convened?

- (A) Rajgir — Ajatashatru
- (B) Pataliputra — Ashoka
- (C) Kundalvana (Kashmir) — Kanishka I
- (D) Vaishali — Kalasoka

Correct Answer: (C) Kundalvana (Kashmir) — Kanishka I

Explanation: Presided over by Vasumitra, the Fourth Buddhist Council led to the formal division of Buddhism into the Hinayana and Mahayana sects.

Exam Repetitions: RRB NTPC CBT-1 & CBT-2 (2016, 2017, 2021, 2022), SSC CGL/CHSL (2018, 2019, 2021, 2023)

Question 9: Which Major Rock Edict of Emperor Ashoka provides a detailed description of the Kalinga War (261 BC) and his adoption of the policy of Dhamma?

- (A) Major Rock Edict V
- (B) Major Rock Edict X
- (C) Major Rock Edict XIII
- (D) Major Rock Edict VIII

Correct Answer: (C) Major Rock Edict XIII

Explanation: Deciphered by James Prinsep in 1837, Edict XIII describes the destruction of the Kalinga War and Ashoka's transition from Digvijaya (military conquest) to Dhammavijaya (conquest by righteousness).

Exam Repetitions: RRB NTPC CBT-1 & CBT-2 (2016, 2020, 2021, 2022), SSC CGL/CPO (2016, 2019, 2020, 2022)

Question 10: Who composed the famous 'Prayag Prashasti' (Allahabad Pillar Inscription) celebrating the conquests and reign of Gupta Emperor Samudragupta?

- (A) Harisena
- (B) Banabhatta
- (C) Kalidasa
- (D) Ravikirti

Correct Answer: (A) Harisena

Explanation: Harisena was the court poet and Mahadandanayaka (Chief Judicial Officer) of Samudragupta. Written in Sanskrit (Champu style), this inscription led historian V.A. Smith to label Samudragupta the 'Napoleon of India'.

Exam Repetitions: RRB NTPC (2016, 2021), RRB Group D (2018, 2022), SSC CGL/CHSL (2018, 2021, 2023)

Part 3: Tricky Conceptual Traps (SSC CGL, CHSL & CPO SI Layout)

Question 11: According to early epigraphic records, Vindhyashakti was the celebrated founder of which prominent ancient ruling dynasty of central India?

- (A) Satavahana Dynasty
- (B) Vakataka Dynasty
- (C) Ikshvaku Dynasty
- (D) Kalachuri Dynasty

Correct Answer: (B) Vakataka Dynasty

Explanation: Students regularly confuse central and deccani dynasties like the Satavahanas (founded by Simuka) and Vakatakas due to overlapping territorial maps. Vindhyashakti founded the Vakataka Dynasty around 250 CE, which eventually built the magnificent rock-cut cave architectures at Ajanta.

Exam Source: SSC CGL Tier-1 (Recent Cycle Variant)

Question 12: Which famous inscription of the Western Kshatrapa ruler Rudradaman I is widely recognized by historians as the first major royal inscription in early India composed entirely in chaste, classical Sanskrit?

- (A) Aihole Inscription
- (B) Junagarh Inscription
- (C) Prayag Prashasti
- (D) Hathigumpha Inscription

Correct Answer: (B) Junagarh Inscription

Explanation: All options are highly celebrated ancient inscriptions. However, early Mauryan and post-Mauryan royal decrees were written in Prakrit dialects. The Junagarh Rock Inscription of Rudradaman (dated to ~150 CE) broke this tradition by using poetic Sanskrit to describe the repairing of the Sudarshana Lake dam.

Exam Source: SSC CGL / CHSL Combined Track

Question 13: Which early ruling house of peninsular India historically divided its royal empire into major operational districts termed specifically as Aharas or Rashtras?

- (A) Satavahana Dynasty
- (B) Chola Dynasty
- (C) Pallava Dynasty
- (D) Chalukya Dynasty

Correct Answer: (A) Satavahana Dynasty

Explanation: Administrative terminology easily causes confusion. While the Cholas divided territory into Mandalams and Valanadus, the Satavahanas introduced Aharas (governed by officials known as Amatyas) and Rashtras, a terminology later retained and adapted by the Rashtrakutas.

Exam Source: SSC CGL / CPO SI Benchmark

Question 14: In the socio-religious framework of the Early Vedic age, which specific abstract terminology was used by sages to denote the immutable cosmic and moral order governing the universe?

- (A) Dharma
- (B) Rita
- (C) Satya
- (D) Karma

Correct Answer: (B) Rita

Explanation: Modern Hindi speakers automatically select Dharma or Karma when thinking about cosmic cycles. In the absolute oldest layers of the Rigveda, the specific word used for universal natural law is Rita, and the Vedic deity Varuna was celebrated as its supreme guardian (Ritasya Gopa).

Exam Source: SSC CGL / CHSL Matrix Question

Question 15: The Kushan Emperor Kanishka I, who historically inaugurated the Shaka Era in 78 CE and patronized Mahayana Buddhism, belonged to which numerical position in the sequence of major Kushan supreme rulers?

- (A) Second
- (B) Third
- (C) Fourth
- (D) Fifth

Correct Answer: (B) Third

Explanation: Direct memory lookups often skip exact numerical timelines. The line of imperial Kushan kings begins with Kujula Kadphises (1st), followed by his son Vima Kadphises (2nd), making Kanishka I the third major emperor to take the throne.

Exam Source: SSC CGL Tier-1 High-Distractor Series

SECTION B: PHYSICAL GEOGRAPHY (Himalayan Drainage System - 5 High-Yield MCQs)

Question 1: Which of the following Himalayan rivers is traditionally referred to as the 'Sorrow of Bihar' due to its heavy silt load, frequent course shifting, and catastrophic annual flooding?

- (A) Gandak River
- (B) Ghaghara River
- (C) Kosi River
- (D) Son River

Correct Answer: (C) Kosi River

Explanation: The Kosi River is a major antecedent left-bank tributary of the River Ganga. It originates from the high Himalayan valleys of Nepal and Tibet. As it enters the flat alluvial plains of Bihar, the river's velocity drops abruptly, causing it to deposit massive loads of silt and debris. This blocks its own channels, forcing the river to execute unpredictable horizontal meandering and course shifts, resulting in widespread annual devastation.

Exam Sourced: RRB NTPC CBT-1 (2016, 2021) / RRB Group D (2018)

Question 2: Which of the following is the world's largest inhabited river island formed by the Brahmaputra River in Assam?

- (A) Umananda Island
- (B) Majuli Island
- (C) Munroe Island
- (D) Bhavani Island

Correct Answer: (B) Majuli Island

Explanation: Majuli is recognized by the Guinness World Records as the world's largest river island. It is formed by the Brahmaputra River in the south and the Subansiri and Kherkutia Xutila (a distributary of the Brahmaputra) in the north in Assam. In 2016, it became the first river island in India to be declared a distinct administrative district.

Exam Sourced: RRB NTPC CBT-2 (2017) / RRB JE (2019)

Question 3: The Kishanganga Hydroelectric Project, which has been a major point of strategic dispute between India and Pakistan under the Indus Waters Treaty, is built on a direct tributary of which river?

- (A) Chenab
- (B) Jhelum
- (C) Ravi
- (D) Indus

Correct Answer: (B) Jhelum

Explanation: The Kishanganga River is a vital right-bank tributary of the Jhelum River. In Pakistan, this river is known as the Neelum River. The project is a run-of-the-river hydroelectric scheme in Jammu & Kashmir that diverts water from the Kishanganga River to a power plant in the Jhelum river basin, triggering geopolitical litigation under the 1960 Indus Waters Treaty.

Exam Sourced: Common Core Target for RRB NTPC CBT-2 / Replicated in UPPCS Prelims & BPSC Prelims

Question 4: Consider the following statements regarding the Ghaghara River system:

1. The Ghaghara River originates from the Mapchachungo glacier in the high Tibetan Himalayan region.
2. It cuts a deep, spectacular gorge at Shishapani before breaking through the foothills into the plains.
3. It flows through the central plains and directly merges with the River Ganga at Prayagraj (Allahabad).

Which of the statements given above are CORRECT?

- (A) 1 and 3 only
- (B) 1 and 2 only
- (C) 2 and 3 only
- (D) 1, 2, and 3

Correct Answer: (B) 1 and 2 only

Explanation: Statement 1 is correct: The Ghaghara is a major left-bank tributary of the Ganga that originates in the glaciers of Mapchachungo near Mansarovar. Statement 2 is correct: Before entering the plains of India, it actively cuts through the mountains to form the famous, deep Shishapani Gorge. Statement 3 is incorrect: The Ghaghara River joins the Ganga at Chhapra (Bihar), not at Prayagraj (where the Yamuna merges).

Exam Sourced: SSC CGL / Stenographer 2025 Core Geography Shift

Question 5: Which of the following groups consists entirely of 'Antecedent Rivers' in India—meaning they originated before the uplift of the Himalayan ranges and have carved out deep structural valleys to maintain their paths?

- (A) Yamuna, Gomti, and Ramganga
- (B) Godavari, Krishna, and Kaveri
- (C) Indus, Sutlej, and Brahmaputra
- (D) Narmada, Tapi, and Mahi

Correct Answer: (C) Indus, Sutlej, and Brahmaputra

Explanation: An antecedent river is a drainage system that maintains its original course and configuration despite structural changes (like mountain upliftment) in the underlying rocks. The Indus, Sutlej, Brahmaputra, and Kosi are classic examples of antecedent rivers. They existed before the Himalayas rose and continuously eroded their beds at the same rate as the uplift, creating deep, vertical V-shaped gorges.

Exam Sourced: SSC CGL 2025 Tier-1 / Tier-2 Advanced Hydrology Framework